

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

What Does Grace Look Like?

The first week back from spring break, Ms. Calloway introduced the word.

"Friends," she said, "this week we are starting our last unit. The biggest word. The word the whole year has been building up to." She wrote it on the board, very carefully, in big letters.

GRACE

The kids stared at it.

"Grace," said Ms. Calloway, "is one of those words that grown-ups use in church, and grown-ups use in books, and grown-ups use when they are talking about how somebody danced. But the kind of grace we are going to learn about is none of those things. The kind of grace we are going to learn about is a CHOICE. Grace is a choice you make about how to treat somebody — usually somebody who has not earned it."

She let that sit.

"Grace," said Sammy, "is when you are kind to somebody who is not being kind to you. Grace is when you give somebody another chance, even when they have not asked for one. Grace is when you understand that everybody is having a hard day sometimes, and you decide to be soft anyway."

"Grace is not weakness," said Sammy. "Grace is chosen kindness. Anybody can be kind to a kind person. That is easy. That is not grace. That is just being polite. Grace is when

somebody has been hard, or rude, or mean — and you decide, on purpose, to give them something they did not earn."

Sammy paused.

"Why would anybody do that?"

The kids looked at each other.

"Because," said Sammy, "the world is hard. Because everybody is carrying things you cannot see. Because if everybody only got the kindness they earned, nobody would ever get any extra. Because the world gets less hard, by a little, every single time somebody gives away kindness for free."

Sammy held up the anchor chart.

GRACE

Kindness you CHOOSE to give To somebody who did not EARN it Because the world is hard for everybody And softness, freely given, makes it less hard The class was quiet.

Then Marcus put his hand up.

"Like — when the new kid sits alone at lunch, and somebody just goes and sits with them?"

"Yes, Marcus. Exactly. That is one of the simplest, clearest examples of grace there is."

"Like when Jaylen rebuilt the tower with me, after I knocked it down?" "Yes, Marcus. Yes. That is grace. Jaylen did not have to rebuild that tower with you. He could have been mad. He could have walked away. He chose to rebuild it with you. That was grace."

Marcus thought about this. He had never, until this moment, recognized what Jaylen had done as anything other than the way kindergarten worked. Now — now he saw it.

"That was really nice of him," he said quietly.

"Yes it was, Marcus. It was grace."

Then Mia raised her hand.

"Is it grace when my dog jumps on the couch even though he is not supposed to, and I let him, because he is so happy?"

The class laughed.

"That is almost grace, Mia. That is grace with limits. Grace is a choice. But grace is not the same as letting people — or dogs — do whatever they want with no boundary. Grace has a kind of strength inside it. We are going to talk about grace with limits later in this unit."

Then Sofia raised her hand.

"Can you give grace to yourself?"

Ms. Calloway stopped.

"Sofia," she said, "what a beautiful, beautiful question. Yes. Yes. The first person you give grace to should be yourself. Self-grace is when you say to yourself, on a hard day, you are doing your best. You did not have to be perfect today. You are allowed to be tired. You are allowed to mess up. You are loved anyway. That is grace, given to yourself, for free. That is one of the most important kinds of grace there is."

Sofia smiled.

This is the start of Unit Four.

The whole year, all of it — Unit One, Unit Two, Unit Three — has been building to this moment. Knowing yourself. Being kind to yourself. Forgiving others. All of it was the foundation. Grace is the roof. You cannot have a roof without walls. You cannot have walls without a floor. You cannot have a floor without a foundation. The reason Ms. Calloway is teaching grace last is not because grace is the hardest. It is because grace is the highest. You build up to it. Brick by brick. Across an entire year. And then, in April, you teach the kids the word. The ten kids of Room 12 are ready for the word.

That is more than most six-year-olds in the world have. That is more than most thirty-year-olds, honestly. Most

thirty-year-olds are still building their foundation.

But the kids of Room 12 — eight months in, with Sammy in the box and the basket on the windowsill and ten brown journals in ten cubbies — the kids of Room 12 have the foundation.

Now we put the roof on.